

DO ANIMALS HAVE RIGHTS?

We gather here today to debate the subject of animal rights. Humans often consider the effects they have as a society on the environment and so on. Understandably, they want to establish whether their actions infringe on the rights of others. But what rights do they have to the animals that live among them? Is it right that they do what they want with animals? Let the debate commence, but without fighting like cats and dogs . . .

COMPANIONS

Humans say that we are their best friends, but some are very cruel to us. We support neutering and spaying so that unwanted animals do not end up in shelters or, worse, being put to sleep. The more exotic creatures among us should not be kept as pets, and humans who breed us should do so with great consideration and care. Owning a pet is not a short-term novelty gift but a long-term rewarding investment.

ANIMAL TESTING

Millions of us are killed, poisoned, or blinded each year in laboratories, testing cosmetic, medical, and household products for humans. We understand that people benefit from animal research—the polio vaccine alone has saved millions of lives. However, there are often reliable alternatives to animal testing, such as computer simulation and human volunteers.

WILDLIFE

Grrreat arguments, thank you. I'll add that hunting wild animals not only kills and injures them, but it also plays with nature's balance. Poaching and smuggling these animals is also an intrusion on their way of life. Hunters may insist that they have a right to kill for food or because it is legal or good for population control, but more responsible action must be taken. Protection programs and conservation projects are the way forward.

WORKING ANIMALS

Animals work hard for humans on farms and as labor. We also entertain you in circuses, races, zoos, rodeos, races, the bullring, and in movies and on television, as well as helping some disabled people. You benefit from our work, so can we not benefit from humane treatment?

PRO ANIMALS

We stand against cruelty toward, and human exploitation of, all animals. We suffer pain and deserve proper and responsible treatment. Humans have a saying they use—do unto others as you would have them do unto you. Practice what you preach! This must surely apply to us creatures, too. It's inhumane to regard us differently. Here are some examples, if it pleases the court . . .